raises the finger and says: Bring up your children more socialistically, they are labile! Over the weekend father has to join the works' militia, mother goes to ZV [civil defence], the son to the GSF [an organisation for paramilitary and military sports training], and the daughter to the DRK [German Red Cross] – everything for the protection of the Politburo caste!

We demand that all restricted areas in the GDR must be free again. Our peasants must be able to use the restricted areas, which are the size of Luxembourg, for productive agricultural work. To start with, the minefields can be cleared by those who gave the orders to mine them.

After publication of the document, media coverage was worse than anticipated, and Honecker feared a public relations nightmare when the issue was amplified by Western TV, and beamed into East German homes. As the crisis stewed, he suspected, wrongly, that the story was cooked-up by Der Spiegel and the Federal Intelligence Service. After making minor modifications and embellishments to the text, he instructed the GDR Foreign Ministry to take the highly unusual step of shooting-off an angry telegram to Der Spiegel's office in Hamburg:

In the last few months, your paper has maliciously slandered the German Democratic Republic and its allies to an ever-increasing extent and has deliberately attempted to poison relations between the German Democratic Republic and the Federal Republic of Germany through fabricated news and reports.

Eventually, after months of trying to suss out the author of the supposed manifesto, the Stasi arrested Hermann von Berg, a disgruntled professor at the economics section of Berlin's Humboldt University. As a devout Marxist, von Berg was motivated by a hatred of injustice and an ardour for decency in SED affairs. Although he issued a swift denial, von Berg later admitted dictating the manifesto to Der Spiegel correspondent Ulrich